

ments for the performance of his duties. The opinion of these medical authorities, and of the army doctors consulted by Mayne, is that the incidence of cholera is well above normal now; that it will reach its peak in December; and that the number of cases may be unmanageable—50,000 a week was the figure mentioned. The main needs are Medical and Health Officers, and subordinate personnel to help them, and a mass campaign of cholera inoculations. Paton told Mayne that he had only 6,200 civil hospital beds in the whole province (outside Calcutta, I presume). If this figure is correct the number is terribly inadequate. Cholera epidemics are, of course, dealt with by special emergency methods, and one would not contemplate the establishment of regular hospitals for cholera patients, but in Mayne's view the men and equipment available are quite inadequate for present needs. Paton is trying to get 50 fully qualified doctors from the army for health work, and 250 Sub-Assistant Surgeons, and 500 Health Assistants from local sources to work under them. The Health Assistants are non-technical subordinates who can be entrusted with elementary duties of sanitary inspection and so on.

In Mayne's opinion the Bengal authorities have shown little imagination or energy in getting the drugs they require. There has, according to him, been no attempt at local procurement, and there seems to have been no approach to the Central Government for help. Hance, Cotter, and one of Hance's staff officers now have this matter in hand. Auchinleck and Mayne made it clear that we must not, in dealing with the Press and the public, give the impression that the army can provide more than a fraction of the medical relief required.

Finally Mayne expressed the gravest doubts about Rutherford's grip on the situation and determination to deal with it. Rutherford expressed surprise at Mayne's anxiety about the general situation, and said that he thought much too much was being made of it. He then retired to Darjeeling for a rest, and Hance has had to follow him there for consultation. When I was in Calcutta, he mentioned to me his wish to go to Darjeeling for a few days rest. As he was obviously not pulling his weight, I told him he could go as soon as he was satisfied that the measures I had initiated were in train. He said he had had no leave since he was appointed to Bihar. My confidence in Rutherford had already been shaken by his apparent reluctance to use the Supply Department officers referred to in paragraph 5 of my last letter. I am quite clear that we must have a first-class man in Bengal as soon as possible.

6. I telegraphed the substance of Mayne's report to you on the evening of 7th November,⁶ making it clear that the appreciation was Mayne's and that the facts have still to be examined in greater detail. I have called for a report about the possibility of having people who pilfer or misappropriate foodgrains tried by special tribunals. I am also getting an official appreciation of the state of medical relief and of the immediate requirements.

7. The Provinces other than Bengal and the States seem to be managing their food economy adequately. The Press do not seem satisfied about Orissa, though Lewis has not yet told me about anything is [*sic*] seriously wrong. His view is that Parlakimedi has shown a good deal of courage, and that the Press criticisms are largely a political "stunt". There is distress in Cochin and Travancore, and C. P. Ramaswami Aiyar has his critics. But on the whole the various Governments seem to be holding their own. The recent cyclone in Madras was worse than was at first supposed, but will not, I hope, affect the general position.

The Punjab is going to be my worst difficulty. I doubt if the Punjab Ministers are the villains they are sometimes represented to be. In the matter of food, and perhaps in other matters, Chhotu Ram is the strong man. He has a very limited outlook, and is fanatically convinced of his mission to increase the prosperity of the Punjabi farmer. He and his colleagues can point to confusion and lack of consideration both at the Centre and in the other provinces. Our Central food policy has been so hand to mouth that inconsistencies and apparent discourtesies have been unavoidable. Bengal is alleged to have made large profits on Punjab wheat, and the United Provinces wheat prices have been considerably higher than Punjab prices. Hutchings is patiently examining and rectifying these and other anomalies as quickly as he can, but in the meantime the Punjab Ministry—intensely bitter at being pilloried as a set of Shylocks⁷—are casting them in our teeth, and are doing all they can to commit themselves irrevocably to non-cooperation with us. They do not see that food is a world issue, and that it is not enough to work—more or less—up to an arbitrary export quota. Nothing short of a food administration reaching right down to the villages and gradually effecting a monopoly, statutory price control, and rationing in the large towns, will do. Glancy's political training inclines him, I am told, to be the Punjab Ministry's advocate with me rather than my advocate with the Punjab Ministry. I will see what I can do with him when he is here for the Governors' meeting on 19th and 20th November. I shall go to the Punjab and N.-W.F.P. on the 24th November.

8. Compared with food, other matters are not very significant at the moment. You suggest that the principles of the Swiss Constitution might be given a trial in Bengal. I see no present hope of success in this. One of the worst features in the situation is the reckless way in which political capital is made of the Bengal trouble, and party feeling is so high that a coalition simply would not work. Moreover, the present Bengal Ministry has a substantial majority in the Legislature, and the Ministers are, I believe, as competent a lot as we are likely to get. Coupland's theories have had a mixed reception. The Muslims regard them as a sign of grace. The Hindus reject them entirely, and at least one

⁶ In tel. 2451-S. L/PO/10/17.

⁷ The money lender in Shakespeare's *Merchant of Venice*.

newspaper and a leading Editor with whom I had a talk have expressed their ardent admiration for the British system, i.e. the counting of heads.

There is little serious political discussion in the Press. Sastri's open letters⁸ evoked some comment, and almost every editorial ends with the suggestion that the release of the Congress leaders and frank discussions are a panacea for all ills and discontents. Mody and N. R. Sarker have just issued a joint statement⁹ pressing me to make a political move. But I doubt if anybody really expects such a move at present. I have seen few political visitors—Sreenivasan, Editor of the *Hindu* is the most important, and I declined to be pumped by him. In a subsequent conversation with Jenkins he displayed bitter hostility to Jinnah and all his works.

9. The Executive Council agreed on the 4th November to delegate to the Supreme Commander, South-East Asia, the powers of the Commander-in-Chief to the extent required. There was no discussion and I am sure I was right to insist on the circulation of all the documents. The existence of a memorandum by Winston, and of the connected directive to the Commander-in-Chief,¹⁰ could hardly have been concealed. Complete disclosure involved no serious risks and removed all possibility of suspicion.

10. I have not yet made up my mind about the two impending vacancies in the Executive Council. I am almost certain that Twynam must succeed Maxwell. In the Finance Membership, I feel I should like to appoint an Indian, as they have got to learn to manage their own finances sooner or later. Mudaliar is the only one I can see for the post at present; but he would have to be supported by an official of something like the present Finance Member's standing. If an Indian is not appointed and in the absence of a first-class appointment from home, it may be best for the time being to extend Raisman. Raisman has been concerned with our War finance from the first, and while a first-class man from the Treasury might be an improvement, a political chief underpinned by one of Raisman's present subordinates might be the reverse. I hope to telegraph to you about this before very long.

11. I have told the External Affairs Department to take up again the elevation of Bajpai to Ministerial status, and have asked you to make the future correspondence official. I am consulting the Department about Bajpai's expenses, and will go into the matter with Raisman in due course. . . .

[The last sentence of para. 11, containing personal comments; para. 12, on Sir Hassan Suhrawardy; and para. 13, on the proposed extension of the jurisdiction of the Federal Court, omitted.]

14. My immediate programme, as far as I can now foresee it, is as follows. I preside at the Governors' meeting on 19th and 20th November. You may be interested in the papers¹¹ circulated for the meeting, of which I enclose a copy.

You will see that I am making a start on Post-War Reconstruction—a difficult task with finance so very uncertain. I will let you have a copy of the proceedings in due course. On the 24th November I fly to Lahore, and on 27th fly on to Peshawar. At both places I shall be concerned mainly with food. I return to New Delhi on 30th November, and shall probably address a meeting of Residents on 6th December. I leave New Delhi again on 11th December for Cuttack, Shillong, and Calcutta, returning on 21st December. Food will again be the main item to be considered, but at Calcutta I hope to address the annual meeting of the Associated Chambers of Commerce on 20th December.

[Para. 15, on lack of news on Sir J. Herbert's condition; and para. 16, on a proposal to transfer control of the Persia and Iraq Command to New Delhi, omitted.]

⁸ Mr Srinivasa Sastri's open letters of 24 October to Mr Amery, Lord Wavell and Mr Gandhi urged them to help solve the Indian deadlock.

⁹ This statement, which appeared in the Indian Press on 8 November, called for the release of the Congress leaders followed by the formation of a national government on the basis of the principles of the Cripps Offer.

¹⁰ L/WS/1/1273: ff 102-7.

¹¹ Nos. 197 and 198.

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Field Marshal Viscount Wavell to Mr Amery

Telegram, L/E/8/3320: f 300

MOST IMMEDIATE

NEW DELHI, 9 November 1943, 11.10 pm

PERSONAL

Received: 9 November, 9 pm

2463-S. A Bengal member tabled resolution for the current session of Central Assembly recommending appointment by Governor-General in Council of Committee to enquire into the causes of Bengal famine effectiveness of preventive and remedial measures suitability of administrative organisation in charge of famine zone and adequacy or otherwise of relief measures. Resolution was included in business for 9th November and routine decision was taken to oppose it.

2. On November 8th European group tabled two amendments recommending appointment of "Royal Commission or Judicial Committee" latter to be presided over by High Court Judge and extension of terms of reference to include accuracy or otherwise of mortality statistics steps taken to counteract or mitigate effects of starvation and malnutrition in children and measures to prevent recurrence. Third amendment proposed by member of Moslem League who may however be acting independently recommended Royal Commission

on general food situation with administrative reference to Bengal and possibility of improving distribution and price control. (? In) conversation with Food Secretary European Group stated they did not think immediate enquiry essential but would press for constructive enquiry as soon as conditions permitted.

3. As we were faced with unanimous demand for enquiry from non-official elements in Assembly matter was taken in Council on the eighth evening. Council decided: *First* that immediate enquiry would divert Ministerial and official attention from far more urgent work and would be disastrous even if competent personnel to conduct it could be spared, and that resolution and amendments must be opposed; and *second* that opposition must be coupled with clear indication that we are not opposed in principle to enquiry.

Opinion on second was divided some members urging that undertaking to consider possibility of enquiry would suffice and others that definite undertaking to hold enquiry at appropriate time must be given. Majority favoured definite undertaking and this was final sense of meeting. It is agreed that Food Member should endeavour to settle form of words which would ensure co-operation of European Group and should discuss further with me before resolution came on.

4. Food Member this morning (corrupt group) withdrawal of resolution and amendments by promising three days instead of two discussion on food. Dates uncertain but probably 12, 15 and 16th November. As enquiry will inevitably be urged during discussion we have still to be clear as to our line.

5. (? On) decision of Council it would be necessary if forced into the open to refuse immediate enquiry on grounds:—(a) that adequate body could not be constituted in war time; (b) that effect on morale of services and communal relations would be disastrous; (c) that scope of enquiry cannot be determined while we are still dealing with crisis.

But we should at the same time have to accept principle of enquiry with reservation that time, terms of reference and composition of enquiring body would have to be considered later and that appointment of Royal Commission would be a matter for H.M.G. We should also stress view that enquiry must be constructive and devoted to preventing recurrence of famine, curing effects of malnutrition and improving economic conditions rather than to allocation of responsibility for alleged administrative failures.

6. I shall mention matter in Council again and ensure that we do not commit ourselves unnecessarily. I will keep you informed of developments.

215

*Field Marshal Viscount Wavell to Mr Amery**Telegram, L/E/8/3320: f 299*

PRIVATE

9 November 1943

2464-S. My immediately preceding telegram. My own view was and is that enquiry now would be disastrous and that enquiry at future date is undesirable. Council agreed with one dissentient about immediate enquiry. But majority, including Chief and Benthall, held that we could not decline to hold enquiry ourselves or to recommend H.M.G. to appoint Commission when crisis is over without appearing indifferent to the very real concern of all parties and communities about breakdown of Bengal administration and danger of recurrence. With one exception members who did not go so far thought we must undertake to enquire in our own time which amounts in practice to much the same thing.

2. I can overrule my Council on ground that interests of Bengal are essentially affected. But had resolution been moved to-day I should certainly not have done so because case for enquiry is not limited to alleged administration failure but extends to broad economic issues and feeling is so unanimous and strong that I should not be on good ground in disregarding it.

216

*Mr Amery to Field Marshal Viscount Wavell**Telegram, L/E/8/3320: f 301*

INDIA OFFICE, 9 November 1943, 6.45 pm

2570I. Mayor of Calcutta¹ has sent to Private Secretary to King telegram repeated in my next telegram. Wardlaw-Milne has been pressing² in the House for an enquiry after the present food situation is over. I have remained non-committal but do not wish to close the door to this possibility entirely. Suggest if you agree that you convey acknowledgment to Mayor of Calcutta on behalf of King's Private Secretary, adding if you see fit that matter has been referred to me as Minister responsible. I should then take no further action. We need, however, I think, to consider whether an enquiry would be advisable later as pressure for this may develop, and might I suppose even be asked for by Provincial Government.

¹ Mr Syed Badrudduja.

² See *Parl. Debs.*, 5th ser., H. of C., vol. 392, 12 October 1943, col. 715.

217

Mr Amery to Field Marshal Viscount Wavell

Telegram, L/E/8/3320: f 302

EN CLAIR

INDIA OFFICE, 9 November 1943, 7 pm

25702. Following is Mayor of Calcutta's telegram.

Begins. On behalf of the Members of the Corporation of Calcutta I appeal to His Majesty the King-Emperor to appoint a Royal Commission to investigate the causes that led to the famine in Bengal causing death of thousands of men women and children in the Province. *Ends.*

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Mr Amery to Mr Churchill

L/PO/8/31: f 149

INDIA OFFICE, 9 November 1943

Secretary of State's Minute: Serial No. P. 50/43

Prime Minister

With reference to Casey's reply¹ about Bengal, there is no difficulty about a shorter tenure than 5 years. The 5-year period is conventional and Governors hold office during Pleasure. Wavell has said² that if he can get a first class man he would not object to a shorter period, but I think myself that it would be a pity to appoint anyone for less than three years.

As regards honours, it has been the invariable custom for Governors of Indian Provinces to be knighted ever since the 80's of last century and Presidency Governors are always given the G.C.I.E. I don't think we ought to let custom stand in the way, but before you finally decide, I should like to ask Wavell whether he thinks there would be any considerable objection to Casey holding office without being knighted. What I have in mind is that loyal Indians might regard it as derogatory to the Crown that a Governor should have declined a high honour which is always given. The Congress, of course, makes a point of its members not accepting honours from the Crown.

L. S. AMERY

¹ No. 212.

² No. 192.

219

War Cabinet W.M. (43) 152nd Conclusions, Minute 2

R/30/1/4: ff 107-10

Those present at this meeting held at 10 Downing Street, S.W. 1, on 10 November 1943 at 6 pm were: Mr Churchill (in the Chair), Mr Attlee, Mr Anthony Eden, Sir John Anderson, Mr Ernest Bevin, Mr Oliver Lyttelton, Mr Herbert Morrison, Field Marshal J. C. Smuts

Also present during discussion of item 2 were: Lord Beaverbrook, Mr Amery, Sir Archibald Sinclair, Sir Stafford Cripps, Lord Leathers, Lord Woolton, Mr Richard Law, Lord Cherwell, Mr Harcourt Johnstone

SHIPPING

Indian Grain requirements

(Previous Reference: W.M. (43) 131st Conclusions, Minute 1)¹

On the 24th September the War Cabinet had authorised the shipment of up to 200,000 tons of food grains to India by the end of 1943 and had agreed that the position should be reviewed again at the end of the year in the light of the Indian harvests.

The War Cabinet now had before them a Memorandum by the Secretary of State for India (W.P. (43) 504)² suggesting that further review could not be postponed until the end of the year.

THE SECRETARY OF STATE FOR INDIA said that the food situation in India gave cause for grave anxiety. The Indian rice harvest would not reach the market until January; and, to support the efforts which were being made to draw a substantial proportion of it into Government hands, it was important that in the meantime imports of food grains should continue steadily. If a decision regarding further imports were delayed until the end of the year, there would be a dangerous interruption in the flow of supplies. The Government of India took the view³ that the minimum required to give them a fighting chance of extracting supplies from cultivators and restoring confidence was an assurance that an import of 50,000 tons of food grains per month would be maintained for a year. In view of the shipping difficulties, the Secretary of State was not prepared to press the War Cabinet to commit themselves to a long-term programme of this kind; but he did think it essential that arrangements should be made to ship to India from Australia (i) a further 50,000 tons of wheat before the end of 1943, in addition to the shipments already authorised; and (ii) another 100,000 tons of wheat in January/February 1944.

THE MINISTER OF WAR TRANSPORT said that it would be impracticable to

¹ No. 139.

² No. 207.

³ No. 203.

provide shipping for any additional shipments of wheat from Australia to India in the remaining months of 1943. In the first two months of 1944, however, it should be possible to ship up to 100,000 tons, though this would be at the expense of replenishing the stocks in the Middle East.

“X” The view of the War Cabinet was that an assurance might now be given to the Government of India that arrangements would be made to ship up to 100,000 tons of wheat from Australia to India during the first two months of 1944. It should, however, be made clear that this did not imply any promise to undertake a long-term programme of shipping food grains to India at the rate of 50,000 tons a month.

Canadian Offer of wheat for India

(Previous Reference W.M. (43) 149th Conclusions, Minute 3)⁴

THE SECRETARY OF STATE FOR INDIA said that he had received that day a telegram⁵ indicating that the Canadian Government could make available one 10,000-ton Canadian ship for carrying to India part of the Canadian offer of 100,000 tons of wheat.

The War Cabinet were informed that, if this Canadian ship were made available for this purpose, it would be withdrawn from the pool of shipping available for Anglo-American war purposes. In these circumstances the War Cabinet decided that, in view of their decision of the 2nd November regarding the Canadian offer of wheat for India, they must press the Canadian Government not to use this ship for a purpose which they regarded as wholly uneconomic from the shipping point of view.

The War Cabinet—

- (1) Invited the Minister of War Transport to arrange for the shipment of up to 100,000 tons of wheat from Australia to India in the first two months of 1944.
- (2) Authorised the Secretary of State for India to communicate this decision to the Government of India in the terms indicated at “X” above.
- (3) Invited the Prime Minister to send a personal message to the Prime Minister of Canada deprecating the proposed allocation of a Canadian ship to carry to India part of the Canadian offer of 100,000 tons of wheat. The Minister of War Transport undertook to furnish a draft which might serve as a basis for the Prime Minister’s message.
- (4) Took note, with approval, of the terms of the reply which the Secretary of State for India proposed to give to a Parliamentary Question on the following day⁶ asking whether shipping would be made available to convey to India the wheat and milk which had been offered by the Canadian and South African Governments respectively.

⁴ Not printed.

⁵ See No. 203, note 2.

⁶ *Parl. Deb.*, 5th ser., H. of C., vol. 393, 11 November 1943, cols. 1278–9.

220

*Sir J. Anderson to Mr Amery**L/PO/2/16: f 1*

TREASURY CHAMBERS, WHITEHALL, S.W.1, 10 November 1943

My dear Leo,

I agree with the view in your letter¹ that the problem of India's sterling balances is essentially the same as that which may arise between us and any country with which we have a fixed exchange and in which we have a large necessary war expenditure, thus creating dangers of serious inflation.

But the Indian problem can be distinguished from that of the other countries by the size of the sterling balances, and also by the responsibility we share with the Government of India for coping with inflation.

The Indian sterling balances problem is the only one, so far as we can see at present, which might confront us at the end of the war with a situation comparable to that of the war debts with the U.S.A.

As regards inflation, I do not want to go over the whole subject again, for I think you don't really dissent from the view of other members of the Committee that the Government of India has been perhaps rather slow to recognise what is happening and rather timid in its action. This has been short-sighted in relation to India's own interests and the results are unfortunate for us as well as them.

Yours ever,

JOHN ANDERSON

¹ No. 202.

221

*Field Marshal Viscount Wavell to Mr Amery**Telegram, L/E/8/3320: f 295*

IMPORTANT

NEW DELHI, 11 November 1943, 2.50 pm

Received: 11 November, 2.45 pm

2473-S. Your telegram 25701¹ November 9th. Am communicating acknowledgement to Mayor of Calcutta as proposed.

2. See my telegram 2463-S² November 9th on demand for enquiry. It is now certain that demand will be renewed in forthcoming debate and Council decided yesterday to take the line already approved for resolution withdrawn by European group.

¹ No. 216.² No. 214.

222

Mr Amery to Field Marshal Viscount Wavell

Telegram, L/E/8/3320: ff 296-8

MOST IMMEDIATE

INDIA OFFICE, 11 November 1943, 2.45 pm

PERSONAL

25879. Your 2463-S.¹ I agree that we must refuse an immediate enquiry with wide terms and that grounds (a) and (b) in your para. 5 can suitably be used in debate. I am unwilling to say anything at present stage which might be construed as committing us to such an enquiry as soon as famine crisis is over or within measurable time thereafter, and for that reason should avoid your (c). Consideration which will be present to you though we may not wish to use it in public is that unless its terms of reference were restricted to a degree that would evoke protest enquiry could not fail to be brought into close contact with strategical and other military questions, many of them involving S.E.A.C. and I doubt if any enquiring body could be set up which could be so composed as both to satisfy Indian opinion and also be allowed freely to explore questions of this kind in war time. You will no doubt consider whether you cannot to some extent use argument that you have just had enquiry covering some of the ground in shape of the Gregory Committee and that your Government is still engaged in considering its recommendations, and you may wish to expand ground (a) by reference to diversion of attention of persons busily engaged on war tasks, *vide* Council decision quoted in para. 3 of your 2463.

2. I agree that it is hardly possible from tactical standpoint to refuse outright any enquiry at any stage although enquiry wherever held and whatever its terms can hardly fail to be opportunity for much communal recrimination as well as attacks on H.M.G. (Another ground for not having enquiry during the war is that these would have undesirable reactions on war effort.) Nevertheless I have hopes that you may find it possible without finally rejecting idea of enquiry in principle at least to avoid any definite commitment. If you are pressed you might consider possibility of offering, as war time expedient which would do no harm even if pursued now, prospect of investigation by one or two experts into relation between growth of population and available supplies of food grains. This might at least answer the point about indifference to possible danger of recurrence.

3. I assume that even if an enquiry has to be promised for the future, its composition and terms of reference could in any case be held over for later consideration. *Prima facie* I see strong reason for deprecating form of Royal Commission though I am not sure that any other legitimate form could be

found since Act of 1935 for enquiry investigating the working of provincial Governments. This is another reason for trying to defer action. If any general remarks have to be made about what should be scope of any eventual enquiry, I agree that emphasis should be on constructive aim and there should be no prospect that terms should include search for scapegoats, but experience shows that enquiring bodies never consider themselves debarred from this exercise.

¹ No. 214.

223

Mr Amery to Field Marshal Viscount Wavell

Telegram, L/PO/8/31: f 144

IMMEDIATE

INDIA OFFICE, 11 November 1943, 7.30 pm

PRIVATE

25947. Superintendent Series. Person mentioned in my private and personal 1200¹ of 8th November has replied that he would be willing provided he would not have to stay full five years and need not be made peer or knighted. He does not want to accept any title which would damage his prospects in his home politics or commit himself to full five-year period which would involve missing next election there.

2. I should be glad to know urgently if you would see any strong objection to departure from the long standing custom in the matter of honour. Some high decoration such as C.H. might be conferred but even so it seems possible that many Indians might misinterpret reasons for this departure.

¹ No. 211.

224

Minute by Mr Churchill

L/PO/8/31: f 148

10 DOWNING STREET, WHITEHALL, 11 November 1943

Reference: S. of S. for India's minute of 9.11.43 Serial No. P. 50/43¹

"I will talk it all over with him."²

W. S. C."

¹ No. 218.

² Evidently Mr Casey; see No. 226, para. 5, last sentence.

225

Field Marshal Viscount Wavell to Mr Amery

Telegram, L/PO/8/31: f 139

PRIVATE

12 November 1943, 10.25 pm

SECRET

IMMEDIATE

2491-S. Your private telegram No. 25947¹ dated 11th November. Bengal Governorship. Am delighted Casey is willing and agree he need not stay full five years. There is no repeat no need whatever for any honour or title. Casey's standing is well known and departure from custom will not repeat not be misinterpreted.

2. Please send the following message to Casey from me as soon as you think proper. *Begins* Am delighted that you have accepted Bengal. You will find there magnificent opportunity of public service. The sooner you can arrive the better I shall be pleased. *Ends*.

¹ No. 223.

226

Mr Amery to Field Marshal Viscount Wavell

L/PO/10/21

PRIVATE AND SECRET

INDIA OFFICE, 12 November 1943

Received: 2 December

I brought up the despatch of additional food to India on Wednesday.¹ Earlier discussion with Leathers convinced me that it was no good asking for a previous commitment to announce 50,000 tons a month for 12 months and that my only hope of getting his support was to concentrate on getting an extra 50,000 each in January and February. So after making it quite clear to the Cabinet that India considered the 600,000 tons over twelve months essential, I pressed, as a minimum, for the 100,000 and got it. I did also urge an additional 50,000 in December, but Leathers said that was impossible. He told me, however, afterwards that if he could get any of the January loadings off earlier he would do so. There may also be a possibility of securing some more barley from Iraq later. Meanwhile, Leathers assures me that all except 10,000 tons of the Iraq barley will be shipped by the end of the year.

2. As for the Canadian wheat, a telegram² had just come in from Mackenzie King saying that he was putting 10,000 tons of it on to a ship at Vancouver on the 12th, i.e. today. This also came up at the Cabinet, who felt strongly that in

the present shortage of Canadian–Australian shipping this could not be justified and the Prime Minister has telegraphed to Mackenzie King asking him not to load the ship for India but to return it to the Australian service. I haven't yet heard the result.

3. Judging by the papers, as well as from your telegrams, the situation looks more hopeful and there even seems a prospect, as the rice harvest approaches maturity and looks abundant, of prices coming down. Last year, of course, the crop also I believe looked quite well until it was discovered at the last moment that there was blight in it. I only trust that there will be no such calamity this time, and also that the next Punjab spring crop of wheat will again be a good one.

4. I need not say how greatly interested I was in all you told me in your letter of November 1st³ of your actual experience in Bengal, including Jenkins' diary of your visit to Contai. I have more than once discussed the Bengal situation with Azizul Haque and read his book *Man behind the Plough*.⁴ It is difficult to see what can possibly be done to make any rapid progress even in peace, until the Bengal peasant can be persuaded to realise that a higher standard of living and a smaller family means greater happiness for all concerned.

5. I have telegraphed⁵ to you about Casey, who is willing⁶ to go to Bengal for at any rate three years, but in view of his political ambitions in Australia doesn't want to take a peerage or even a knighthood. I can see some objections from the point of view of Indians, who feel that nobody is entitled to refuse an honour from the King and who may feel that Casey is doing the same kind of thing as Allah Bakhsh⁷ tried to do. I should have thought this could easily be met by saying that in Australia and Canada, just as to some extent here, those who want to take a leading place in the Legislature find it more convenient to remain commoners: Winston himself being an excellent example. Anyhow, I should not myself regard the objection as insuperable. Casey should, I think, fill the bill very well. He has considerable political and diplomatic experience and should know something by now not only of the oriental mind but also of the kind of problems, like inflation, hoarding, &c. with which he will have to cope in Bengal. While perhaps not quite so strong a man as Eric Dudley, I think he could be relied on to be more tactful and perhaps also more co-operative from your point of view. She too is very pleasant and will I think play up. Anyhow, Winston, who is taking wing again,⁸ is going to discuss the matter with Casey in the next few days.

¹ No. 219.

² See No. 203, note 2.

³ No. 199.

⁴ The Book Co., Calcutta, 1939.

⁵ No. 223.

⁶ See No. 212.

⁷ See Vol. III, No. 62, para. 16, No. 69, para. 4 and No. 86, para. 21.

⁸ Mr Churchill left Plymouth on 12 November for the Conferences at Cairo and Teheran which had, as their main object, the formulation of plans for the 'Overlord' invasion of Europe in 1944.

6. As regards political developments, it seems pretty obvious that the food situation will dominate everything for the time being. That might possibly be just as well as it may enable the political situation itself to mature and give you more time to look around. Also, from the point of view of the war, the situation may be so much better as to create a more hopeful setting for anything in the nature of what we discussed before you left. I quite realise, by the way, the difficulty of my coming out⁹ without raising hopes of some new political move, at any rate under present circumstances. If a situation should arise in which I could come without doing harm, or possibly even do good, you will no doubt let me know. I do feel that in so many ways I should gain enormously by even the briefest contact with the situation on the spot and by a further direct personal talk with you when things have shaped themselves somewhat further.

[Para. 7, on the control of the *Civil and Military Gazette*; and para. 8, on the war situation, omitted.]

9. There has been a minor reshuffle of the Government and a somewhat larger one may take place at the end of the year. I am not sure that there are any eager candidates to fill my place and I can hope pretty confidently that our partnership will not be prematurely broken up.

PS.—I enclose a copy of a little book by C. F. Andrews on the Bihar Earthquake¹⁰ which Miss Harrison has sent me. The markings in it are her own. Andrews was, of course, a devoted friend of Gandhi's and the book is enthusiastic about his work and Prasad's on the occasion of the earthquake. We all know that there is a very different side to both these men, but for all that it might interest you to glance at it.

⁹ See No. 194.

¹⁰ C. F. Andrews, *The Indian Earthquake* (London, Allen & Unwin, 1935).

227

Secretary of State to Government of India, Food Department

Telegram, L/E/8/3322: f 105

IMPORTANT

INDIA OFFICE, 13 November 1943, 1 am
25996. Your telegram 2415-S^I of 3rd November. H.M.G. have further considered the shipping for food grains for India. They were informed that it was your view that minimum which would give you a fighting chance as distinct from a good prospect of extracting supplies and restoring confidence is an assurance of 50,000 tons per month for 12 months and authority to make announcement that this has been promised. H.M.G. authorised me to give you an assurance that arrangements will be made to ship up to 100,000 tons of wheat

from Australia to India in the first two months of 1944 in addition to programme already approved and notified to you. They wish me to say, however, that this does not imply any promise to undertake a long term programme of shipping at the rate of 50,000 tons a month.

2. The loading of the additional 100,000 tons of cereals could probably be completed a few weeks earlier than otherwise if you are ready to accept some part of it in Iraqi barley and quantities of barley additional to existing programme of 130,000 tons prove to be available. What are your views?

3. You will doubtless agree that no announcement should be made.

¹ No. 203.

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Government of India, Food Department to Secretary of State

Telegram, L/E/8/3322: f 101

IMPORTANT

NEW DELHI, 13 November 1943, 11.55 pm

Received: 14 November, 1.15 am

9867. Your telegram of 12th November 25996¹ assurance of 100,000 tons in January and February 1944 is most helpful and we are grateful for your help. We hope that decision on question of continuing at least this rate of supply will not be long delayed.

2. We would much prefer even at risk of some delay to have whole of this quantity in wheat.

3. We shall not make any announcement.

¹ No. 227; the date should be 13 November.

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Mr Amery to Mr Churchill¹

Telegram, L/PO/8/31: f 136

INDIA OFFICE, 15 November 1943

GRAND Following personal and secret for Prime Minister from Secretary of State for India.

Wavell reports² Rutherford has been ordered by his doctor to take things easily. He hopes therefore that successor will be chosen and come out with

¹ In sending this telegram to Brigadier Jacob on 15 November for transmission, Mr Turnbull explained that the matter was more urgent than might appear since the person under consideration for the appointment was in Cairo, and Mr Churchill intended to speak to him soon after arrival. L/PO/8/31: f 135.

² In tel. 2498-S of 13 November. L/PO/8/31.

minimum delay. Hope therefore you can reach early decision on proposal under consideration. The more I think of it the more I believe it is the right choice.

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Field Marshal Viscount Wavell to Mr Amery

L/PO/10/21

THE VICEROY'S HOUSE, NEW DELHI, 16 November 1943

PRIVATE AND SECRET

Many thanks for your letter of the 3rd November¹ which arrived on the 13th. I am glad you feel that my visit to Bengal did good. It certainly gave me a much clearer idea than I had before of the nature and size of the food problem there.

2. I have spent a quiet but busy week at New Delhi. Food is still my main concern, and I hope that the Army's presence is now being felt in Bengal though the additional troops will not be fully in position for another week or so.

3. I too was disappointed at the decision over Canadian wheat, and I am sorry that owing to a misunderstanding of Mackenzie King's position we put out a communiqué here announcing the gift when in fact the Canadian communiqué had been held up. The Indian communiqué can have done very little harm as it made it quite clear that the gift was subject to the availability of shipping.² I felt that it was very important to let educated people here know of Canada's sympathy. All the Dominion Governments are doing their best to help.

4. Rutherford has been advised by his doctor that he is not up to a really hard day's work.³ I hope that this is not really so, as there is plenty to do in Bihar when his successor arrives. I was very glad indeed to get your telegrams⁴ about his successor. It is most important that the new man should arrive in Bengal at the earliest possible date. Rutherford will presumably do his best to carry on in the meantime; but the appointment is not one for an invalid. I was a little surprised that Winston's choice reacted favourably; there will of course be no difficulty whatever about titles and honours. Your comment on Freyberg's brain power is just, but he has a greater determination and ability to get things done than anyone I know, and these qualities are a bigger asset than brains in Bengal at the present time.

5. I am very glad that John Anderson is taking the chairmanship of the Cabinet Committee on Indian Finances so seriously. He is perhaps better qualified than any one else at home (except Linlithgow himself) to appreciate what our difficulties are. Mountbatten came to see me the other day and said he

doubted if we were doing all we could, and felt that perhaps we were over-estimating our difficulties. I think that he has been advised by some comparatively junior officers on his Staff and the Americans and does not realise that Linlithgow's representations were fully concurred in not only by the civilian Members of Council best qualified to advise, but by the Commander-in-Chief, and that on the known facts the economic experts at your end have for some months taken a very serious view of the position. With the present trouble about food in Bengal, the evident congestion on the railway system, the falling off in coal production, and the difficulty of keeping essential factories supplied with coal, it is impossible to say with any confidence that India can support her present burdens, let alone taking [take] on new ones. I hope to give Mountbatten a short statement of our views within a few days, and Rowlands, who arrived on 14th November, will be able to help in this. Rowlands is beginning to settle in and will probably be working effectively within a week or so.

[Para. 6, on anti-malaria precautions for air passengers to India, omitted.]

7. My own doings have not been particularly exciting. I have managed to find eight I.C.S. officers to help the Bengal Government run their procurement scheme. Five of these officers are being released by Central Departments, and three (all originally from Bengal) are coming from the Political cadre. The complete procurement scheme of the Bengal Government has not yet been shown to the Executive Council. I understand, however, that the scheme has been approved by the Bengal Government, and that the reduction in the ceiling price for rice which is connected with it was announced by the Bengal Government without reference to the Food Department here. The scheme involves the transfer to the Centre of responsibility for supplying Calcutta (subject to a comparatively small contribution from Bengal); procurement through trade agencies in the rural areas of the Province for the needs of the Defence Services, the provincial reserve, the contribution to Calcutta and the deficit districts; and distribution from the surplus to the deficit districts. I have seen your telegram⁵ expressing your doubts about the Bengal Government's intentions, and appreciate your anxiety. I am, however, quite certain that in the time available the Bengal Government could not have organised a complete monopoly, nor even a monopoly to take all rice offering, and that the arrangements for the procurement of this *Aman* crop had therefore to be less satisfactory than with a strong administration. There is also a psychological factor involved. The villager is

¹ No. 205.

² See No. 209 note 2.

³ See No. 229.

⁴ Nos. 211 and 223.

⁵ 26156 of 13 November. In this telegram, Mr Amery expressed concern that the Bengal procurement scheme might be worked in competition with the trade. In his view, high prices were much the most important element in Bengal's troubles, and a significant difference between Bengal, where there had been real disaster, and other Provinces, where the position had been held, was that in other Provinces procurement schemes had eliminated competition and stabilised prices. L/E/8/3340: ff 200-2.

undoubtedly in an extremely nervous state, probably amounting almost to panic; and attempts at a really thorough wholesale procurement might have a disastrous effect, and lead him to conceal crop; whereas a less drastic procurement may restore confidence. Certainly nothing would be worse than an attempt at wholesale procurement which failed, as it well might. But we must see that the Bengal Government do set up the organisation needed for the effective control of procurement and distribution in future. Detailed work on the procurement scheme should have begun several months ago, but practically nothing was done until after my visit to Calcutta.

8. Except in Bengal, Orissa, Travancore and Cochin, there seems to be no real distress, and I gather that the Madras Government are coping successfully with the effects of a cyclone. I am not entirely happy about Orissa. Lewis tells me in his fortnightly letters⁶ that he is satisfied that conditions are not too bad; but it is clear that there have been deaths from starvation and that some of these have been among the residents of Orissa and not among vagrants from the neighbouring districts of Bengal. There has been a good deal in the press about conditions in Orissa, but as I said in paragraph 7 of my last letter the tone of the press reports is due largely to political animosity.

9. At the other end of the food front, exchanges with the Punjab are just beginning. The Ministers were very much hurt by Hailey's references to the Punjab in the House of Lords,⁷ and thought that the White Paper⁸ had done them gross injustice. Chhotu Ram is particularly sore and complains that he has been treated with "ignominy and ridicule" both here and in London. The Premier's telegram⁹ to you showed that he and his colleagues were a little shaken, and it may be useful for them to realise that there is a public opinion outside the Punjab and that world-wide criticism may be very galling. What we want of the Punjab is the establishment of an efficient food administration covering procurement, the rationing of the larger towns, and control of prices. The Ministers will stick both at rationing and price-control; but I have been privately informed that the Premier would accept price-control if he knew that I would force it on him in the absence of agreement. Chhotu Ram thinks rationing in a surplus area quite ridiculous, and price-control unfair to the farmer. There is no doubt about the sincerity of the Ministers and it is of some interest that Hallett's views both on rationing and on price-control differ from those of the Food Department. Hallett favours a modified rationing system in the large towns under which about half the population are provided for on ration cards, and the well-to-do are left to make their own arrangements. He also seems to believe that price-control is futile unless there are large Government stocks and unnecessary if such stocks exist. I believe that I shall be able to overcome Punjab opposition based on alleged profiteering by other Governments and the like, but it will be very difficult indeed to secure willing agreement

on rationing and price-control. The Sind Ministers broke loose a few days ago, and Dow telegraphed¹⁰ that they were likely to abandon the control of wheat prices which has hitherto been extremely effective. On the 15th November, I approved the issue by the Food Department of a direction under Section 126-A of the Constitution Act forbidding any change without the approval of the Central Government.

10. The debate on food in the Assembly began on Friday the 12th November, and continues today and tomorrow. I understand that a fourth day is to be allowed on Thursday the 18th. So far the debate has not been of high quality, and at the end of the first day the position was still confused. The demand for an enquiry is of course being pressed. We are taking the line indicated in my telegram¹¹ to you on this subject, and I am grateful for your reply¹² showing that you agree generally. An immediate enquiry would, for obvious reasons, be disastrous; but there is a more or less unanimous demand for an enquiry, and after all that has happened in Bengal we cannot reasonably say that no enquiry can be held even when things have returned to normal. The parties are divided on the nature of the enquiry, the Europeans and the Muslim League apparently favouring a Royal Commission, and the Congress pressing for a body appointed here.

11. I noticed the other day that the appreciations of the food position telegraphed to you periodically¹³ by the Food Department were anything but informative and did not seem to cover all the ground. I have had this matter taken up, and the Food Department will, I hope, soon produce something better.

12. You must by now have had the first official report¹⁴ from the Department of Education, Health and Lands about the cholera epidemic in Bengal. All concerned have moved fairly fast since my talk with Mayne, and progress will be reported to you officially once a fortnight.¹⁵

13. I presided at the routine Council meeting on the 10th November. The most controversial item for discussion was a draft Ordinance produced by Maxwell as a substitute for Rule 26 of the Defence of India Rules. The draft gives certain concessions to people detained without trial—they are to be told the substance of the charges against them, and there is to be a six-monthly review of their cases. I am myself doubtful of the wisdom of making these

⁶ L/P&J/5/233. ⁷ *Parl. Debs.*, 5th ser., H. of L., vol. 129, 20 October 1943, cols. 262–70.

⁸ See No. 182, note 2.

⁹ Denying the Punjab's lack of co-operation on the food question and explaining the ways in which it was assisting deficit areas. A copy of Khizar Hyat Khan's telegram and Mr Amery's reply is on L/E/8/3348.

¹⁰ L/E/8/3311: ff 194–6, 198–9.

¹¹ No. 214.

¹² No. 222.

¹³ L/E/8/3307.

¹⁴ L/E/8/4961.

¹⁵ See *ibid.*

concessions which might give Provincial Governments and ourselves a great deal of trouble and will probably not satisfy public opinion. With one or two rather surprising exceptions Members of Council were, however, wholly in favour of the principle of the draft, and subject to the settlement of certain details by Maxwell it will certainly be adopted. Like most matters discussed in Council, it has already been the subject of Press comment.

14. The question of retaliation against South Africa will shortly come before Council. I have seen one peculiarly silly proposal to withdraw from South Africans the privileges of European British subjects under the Code of Criminal Procedure. Legislation on these lines would attract publicity and cause a good deal of annoyance in the Union and would mean almost nothing here. A more important proposal concerns trade relations. Whatever the position in peace time may be, I do not see how in war time India can deny her own goods to South Africa or refuse to take South African goods. For example if we were to debar South Africa from taking our jute fabrics, a supply would undoubtedly be given from British sources or from British and American stocks. Conversely if we refused to take South African goods required for the Defence Services here, they would presumably be bought by His Majesty's Government and brought to India as Army property. I intend to have a talk this week with Shafa'at Ahmad Khan who is in India on a visit. His view seems to be more realistic than that of the Members of Council mainly concerned. He thinks that we ought to approach the South African Government on the franchise question and to give them an opportunity of settling with us before we attempt economic sanctions. I shall have to go into the matter further, but it might be a good plan, if negotiations seemed possible, for me to write a personal letter to Smuts.

[Para. 15, on Sir G. S. Bajpai's emoluments, omitted.]

16. In paragraph 8 of your letter of the 21st October¹⁶ you mentioned the matter of new admissions to the Chamber of Princes. You will since have seen Fitze's letter of November the 6th¹⁷ to Gibson in which he says that it has been decided to call a halt to any further enlargement of the Chamber of Princes for some years to come, or at any rate until the future of the small States can be more clearly visualised.

17. I am worried about coal. A situation seems to me to be developing somewhat on the lines of food shortage, i.e. we are not able to produce our requirements and yet we are nibbling at the problem in a rather leisurely and routine manner. I will try to get a move on but I don't feel it is going to be easy.

18. I gave you some idea of my immediate programme in paragraph 14 of my last letter.¹⁸ At present I have nothing to add.

¹⁶ No. 183.

¹⁷ L/P&S/13/290: f 82.

¹⁸ No. 213.

23 I

Mr Amery to Field Marshal Viscount Wavell

Telegram, L/P&J/8/512: ff 40-2

IMPORTANT

INDIA OFFICE, 18 November 1943, 1 am

PRIVATE

1226. I have reason to believe that when Parliament reassembles on the 23rd amendment to Motion on Address will be moved by certain Conservative Members to the effect that it is regretted no reference was made to the political situation in India and urging that measures should be initiated by Government of India to promote formation of some body of Indians that might make preliminary study of questions which would eventually come under consideration of some Constituent Body. Possible alternative line may be suggestion that Government of India should set up body of experts drawn mainly from outside India, with experience of working of federal constitutions, to make the preliminary study.

2. If Debate proceeds on such lines I should propose to take line that initiative has been passed deliberately by H.M.G. to Indians and it is for them to make use of it. Since 1940 invitations have been held out by H.M.G. to Indians to get together and formulate their own future constitution. It would not be consistent with the undertakings resulting from our declarations that either the Government of India or H.M.G. should make itself responsible for selecting the individuals who should be charged with the task of inquiry, still less for laying down the plan according to which such an inquiry should proceed. On the other hand, if unofficial Indians of position and influence were to set themselves spontaneously to take preliminary steps to find some solution of the constitutional dilemma which would be likely to commend itself generally and so might lead to effective acceptance of our offers, nobody would be better pleased than His Majesty's Government, and they would be prepared to use their good offices in any such way as endeavouring to obtain such expert assistance in the way of eminent jurists with knowledge of federal constitutions and forms of government operative in other countries as any such representative body of Indians might wish. Further, they have no doubt that if such study of the question were located in India the Government of India would be no less happy to afford such facilities as they can at a time when all secretarial staff is very heavily burdened with urgent war work. But I should emphasise that it is not for Government of India to take initiative in framing a plan or any responsibility for its working.

Do you agree to this as the general line to meet this particular suggestion? I have no doubt, however, that the debate will turn mainly on how can Indians

get together while the Congress leaders are detained and on inflation as the cause of famine, etc., arguments I must deal with as best I can.

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Secretary, Government of India, Home Department to Mr Gandhi

L/P&J/8/623: f 200

NEW DELHI, 18 November 1943

Sir,

In reply to your letter of October 26th¹ I am directed to say that since there is no change in your attitude towards the Congress resolution of August 8th, 1942, and Government have received no indication that the views of any of the Members of the Working Committee differ from your own, a meeting between you would appear to serve no useful purpose. Both you and they are well aware of the conditions on which such a proposal could be entertained.

I am to add that the other points in your letter have been noted.

I am etc.,

R. TOTTENHAM

¹ No. 188.

233

Minutes of the Governors' Conference, 19-20 November 1943 (Extract)¹

L/PO/10/21

SECRET

PROCEEDINGS FOR 19TH NOVEMBER 1943

PRESENT

His Excellency the Viceroy.

All Provincial Governors.

IN ATTENDANCE:

P.S.V. acting as Secretary to the Conference.

Sir Theodor Gregory, Economic Adviser to the Government of India.

Mr. R. H. Hutchings, Secretary, Food Department.

INTRODUCTORY

THE VICEROY in opening the Conference said he believed it was the first since 1930, and certainly the first since the passing of the Constitution Act of 1935. The Conference could not take executive decisions; he had himself to consider